

Chapter 5: A Secret on Paper

Jenny held the paper tighter.

Austin's voice was sharper than before.

"Give me that."

It wasn't loud.

But it carried authority.

The kind of voice people usually obeyed without question.

Jenny didn't move.

Instead, she looked down again.

The numbers didn't make sense at first.

Then they did.

Very large investments.

Risk reports.

Asset movements.

And a name at the top.

Austin Blackwood.

Jenny slowly looked up.

"You dropped this."

"I know."

"That's a lot of money."

"I'm aware."

Her grip on the paper loosened slightly.

"So you're not just rich," she said. "You're... *really* rich."

A pause.

Then Austin exhaled through his nose.

"Yes."

Jenny nodded once.

As if that explained everything.

Then she surprised herself.

"So why do you still act like the world is running out of money?"

That question hit differently.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

He stepped closer.

Not aggressive.

Just enough to make the space between them smaller.

"People like me don't stay rich by being careless."

Jenny tilted her head.

"That sounds like fear."

His eyes narrowed.

"It's discipline."

"Same thing, different excuse."

A flicker of something crossed his face.

Annoyance.

Maybe curiosity again.

He reached out.

Not to touch her.

Just to take the paper.

Jenny didn't let go.

For a moment, they both held it.

A silent tug.

Not just over the document.

Something else.

Control.

Austin spoke more quietly now.

"Jenny. I need that back."

Something in her chest tightened at the way he said her name.

Not cold.

Not mocking.

Just... serious.

She let go.

The paper slid into his hand immediately.

He folded it once and tucked it into his coat.

Silence followed.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You should be more careful."

"I usually am."

"Clearly not today."

A pause.

Then, unexpectedly, Austin said,

"I didn't expect you to see it."

Jenny raised an eyebrow.

"That sounds suspicious."

"It's not."

"Everything sounds suspicious when rich people say it."

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

Instead, his expression shifted slightly.

More closed off.

"Forget what you saw."

Jenny blinked.

"Excuse me?"

"You didn't see anything important."

"That looked important."

"It isn't your concern."

Jenny laughed once.

Short.

Sharp.

"Everything becomes my concern when you leave it on my table."

That stopped him.

A real pause this time.

Austin studied her.

Not like a customer now.

Not like a businessman.

Something more careful.

More controlled.

"You're curious," he said.

"I'm observant."

"You're dangerous."

Jenny pointed at him.

"You started this. You came back three times this week on purpose."

A beat.

Austin didn't deny it.

That was new.

Behind them, the restaurant had mostly emptied.

Bao was pretending to clean while watching them like it was live entertainment.

Madam Chen stayed in the kitchen.

But she was definitely listening.

Austin finally spoke.

"I work in markets. Numbers. Risk. Pressure."

Jenny nodded slowly.

"And?"

"And if people see weakness..." he stopped.

He didn't finish.

Jenny softened slightly.

"You think that paper shows weakness?"

His jaw tightened.

"People like me don't survive by showing anything."

That sounded less like arrogance.

And more like experience.

Jenny hesitated.

For the first time, she didn't have a quick reply.

Instead, she said quietly,

"I'm not 'people like you.'"

"I know."

The answer came too fast.

Too honest.

That made her pause.

Outside, the sky darkened.

Evening creeping in.

Austin adjusted his coat.

"I should go."

"Of course you should."

He looked at her.

"Why do you always say it like that?"

"Like what?"

"Like you're pushing me away."

Jenny blinked.

She hadn't noticed she was doing that.

Or maybe she had.

She just didn't know why.

Because something about him...

Stayed in her thoughts longer than she liked.

"Maybe I just don't trust rich traders," she said.

"That's fair."

The honesty surprised her.

He turned slightly toward the door.

Then stopped.

Without looking back, he said,

"I wasn't planning to come here today."

Jenny frowned.

"Then why did you?"

Silence.

A long one.

When he finally spoke, his voice was lower.

"Because I wanted to see you."

The words landed between them like a dropped glass.

Clean.

Sharp.

Unavoidable.

Jenny didn't respond.

Didn't move.

Didn't breathe properly for a second.

Austin finally turned his head slightly.

Just enough to look at her.

"I don't know why," he added.

And then he left.

The door closed behind him.

Quiet.

Final.

Jenny stood still for a long time.

Behind her, Bao whispered,

"Oh my god."

Jenny didn't answer.

Her mind was still stuck on one sentence.

I wanted to see you.

And for the first time...

She didn't know whether she should be angry.

Or afraid.

Or something far worse.

Curious.